



1 The lives of Black Americans in the early 1950s

The end of enslavement

Between 1525 and 1866, around 400 000 people were enslaved and forcibly transported from Africa to North America.

In the US Civil War (1861–65), the northern states (where enslavement was illegal) defeated the southern states (where enslavement was legal).

- **1865:** The Thirteenth **Amendment** to the **Constitution** ended enslavement in the USA.

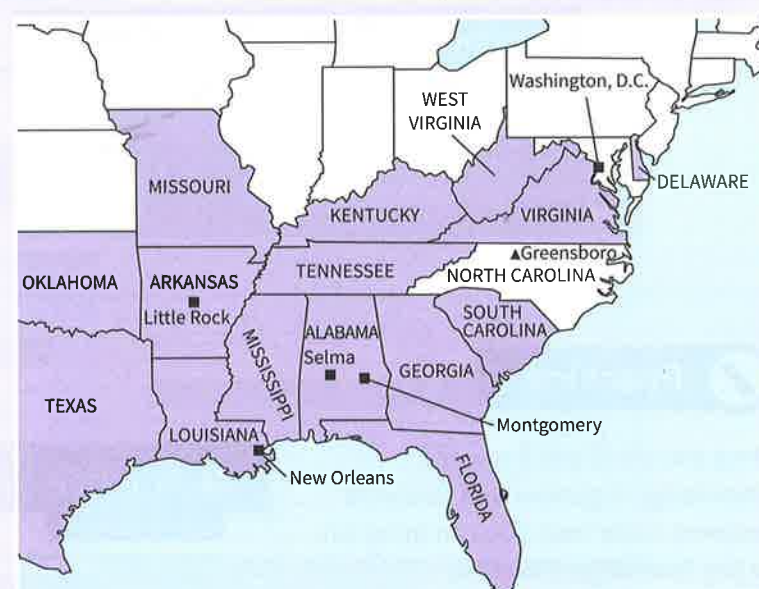
- **1868:** The Fourteenth Amendment guaranteed all citizens 'equal protection of the laws'.
- **1870:** The Fifteenth Amendment guaranteed all citizens the right to vote.

Together, these amendments should have made all Americans equal, but Black people were still racially **discriminated** against socially, politically, and economically. Furthermore, Black Americans living in the north had a different experience from those living in the south.

The legal situation

Two key legal cases ensured discrimination against Black people was legal in the southern states of the USA, despite the amendments.

Case	Ruling
<i>Dred Scott v. Sandford</i> (1857)	All people of African descent, free or enslaved, were not US citizens.
<i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> (1896)	It was legal to segregate white and Black people, provided facilities were ' separate but equal '.



▲ The southern states of the USA enforced segregation into the 1950s

REVISION TIP

Knowing each amendment and legal case will help you to understand the subsequent topics.

Voting rights in the south

Black people were a significant minority in many southern states. In Mississippi, for example, they made up 45% of the population in the 1950s.

'**Jim Crow**' state laws were used to prevent them from having their say:

- Grandfather clause: Black people (whose grandparents had been enslaved) were forced to apply to register to vote.
- Irregular opening times: This limited Black people's access to voter registration offices.

- Literacy test: Black people had to pass a test to register, which was deliberately made almost impossible to pass.
- Poll tax: Black people had to pay a tax before they could vote, which many could not afford.

Black people also faced threats of violence, intimidation, and being sacked if they voted. By 1964, only 6.7% of eligible Black people were registered to vote in Mississippi.

Comparing the north and the south in the early 1950s

Black people faced **prejudice** and discrimination to varying levels in both north and south:

	North	South
Jobs	Low-paid factory jobs. Service jobs in hotels/cafes. Lower wages than white people: 'last hired, first fired' if businesses struggled.	Sharecroppers (tenant farmers). Domestic servants (such as maids and cooks).
Access to public facilities	Access was not segregated.	Access to schools, parks, beaches, cinemas, buses, waiting rooms, and restaurants was segregated; barred from attending universities.
Housing	Mostly lived in inner-city ghettos (crowded, poorer areas).	Mostly lived in poor-quality houses on the edges of small, rural communities; blocked from moving to 'white areas' by landlords.
'Jim Crow' state laws	Did not apply.	Used extensively to prevent Black people from accessing their rights to vote and organise.
Relationship with police/army	Police officers and the legal system racially discriminated against Black people. US Army was segregated until 1948; prejudice remained in both north and south.	

The work of civil rights organisations

Black people established **civil rights** organisations, such as the **NAACP** and **CORE**. Other local, business, and church organisations campaigned for civil rights, too.

NAACP (Founded 1909)	CORE (Founded 1942)
Tactics: Court cases to demonstrate that segregation was against the Constitution.	Tactics: Non-violent direct action , such as marches and sit-ins .
Membership: Black people and older, often middle-class, white people.	Membership: Black people and younger white people, often students.

There was some progress up to 1945, but social changes caused by the Second World War and the growth of the media paved the way for greater successes in the 1950s and 1960s:

- Over a million Black Americans fought during the war; they became determined to fight racism back home.
- By 1962, 90% of US households had a television.
- Newspaper daily sales grew by over 10 million between 1940 and 1950.



Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

Amendment Constitution discriminated segregate separate but equal prejudice 'Jim Crow' state laws civil rights NAACP CORE tactics non-violent direct action sit-in

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

- | | | |
|----|--|--|
| 1 | What did the Thirteenth, Fourteenth, and Fifteenth Amendments to the US Constitution do? | Thirteenth: ended enslavement in the USA; Fourteenth: guaranteed 'equal protection of the laws'; Fifteenth: guaranteed all citizens the right to vote |
| 2 | Which key court case introduced the idea of 'separate but equal'? | <i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> (1896) |
| 3 | Name three forms of discrimination faced by Black people in the south. | Three from: access to public facilities was segregated / barred from attending universities / state laws prevented Black people from voting / blocked from moving into 'white areas' |
| 4 | What did 'Jim Crow' state laws prevent? | They prevented Black people from accessing their rights to vote and organise |
| 5 | How were Black people treated by the police and the legal system? | Police officers and the legal system racially discriminated against Black people in both the north and south |
| 6 | How did the 'grandfather clause' prevent Black people from voting? | Black people (whose grandparents had been enslaved) had to register to vote, and registering to vote was made as difficult as possible |
| 7 | How were literacy tests used to prevent Black people from registering to vote? | They contained questions that were very difficult to answer, making it hard to pass |
| 8 | Black people made up what percentage of Mississippi's population in the 1950s? | 45% |
| 9 | Which organisations campaigned for Black people's civil rights? | NAACP, CORE, local, businesses, and church organisations |
| 10 | What was the primary tactic the NAACP used in the fight for civil rights? | Legal action (court cases) |
| 11 | Which court case decided that all people of African descent, whether enslaved or free, could not be US citizens? | <i>Dred Scott v. Sandford</i> (1857) |
| 12 | What was CORE's primary tactic in the fight for civil rights? | Non-violent direct action |
| 13 | Which civil rights organisation consisted of a lot of students? | CORE |
| 14 | Around how many people were enslaved and forcibly transported from Africa to North America? | 400 000 |
| 15 | Until when was the US Army segregated? | 1948 |

Practice

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: Protesters demonstrate against segregated education in Houston, Texas, in 1947



- 1 Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about the reasons why Black people demanded their civil rights. (4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

- | | |
|------------------------|--|
| (i) What I can infer: | Details in the source that tell me this: |
| (ii) What I can infer: | Details in the source that tell me this: |

- 2 Explain why life was more difficult for Black people in the south than in the north in the early 1950s. (12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- access to public facilities
- 'Jim Crow' state laws.

You **must** also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

Before attempting to answer each question, use the 'BUG' method:

- **Box the command word**, so that you know what you are being asked to do.
- **Underline the key words** (the words that tell you which topic the question is about, and jog your memory about the topic).
- **Glance at the question again**, to pick up any additional information it is giving you and to help you picture what you need to do.

SOURCE TIP

Remember, an inference is information you can extract from a source that is not directly stated, such as, information about emotions, attitudes, or significance.

Always back up your inference with evidence from the source in question, not from your own knowledge.



2 The Civil Rights Movement, 1954-60

Brown v. Topeka, 1954

As a result of *Plessy v. Ferguson*, Black people in the south attended separate schools to white people. White schools were given more money and had better facilities.

The NAACP court case *Brown v. Topeka* challenged *Plessy v. Ferguson*, leading to the events at Little Rock, Arkansas, in 1957.

Features of event	Result	Short-term consequence	Long-term consequence	Outcomes
Black student Linda Brown is supported by the NAACP to go to a white-only school closer to her home than the Black-only school. They argue that segregation is against the Fourteenth Amendment, and demonstrate that segregation made Black children feel unequal.	The Supreme Court overturns <i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> and unanimously decides that 'separate educational facilities are inherently unequal'.	'Separate but equal' is declared unconstitutional.	Other 'Jim Crow' state laws can now be challenged. Yet no deadline is set for integration, so progress is slow as states delay or resist.	- By the summer of 1957, 723 school districts in central states desegregate. - There is much resistance to desegregation of schools in the south. Black students and teachers face hostility and intimidation in integrated schools. Many Black schools are closed. - Hostility reduces membership of civil rights groups. NAACP membership falls by 40% in 1957.

Little Rock High School, 1957

On 3 September 1957, nine Black students supported by the NAACP attempted to join over 1000 white students at Little Rock High School, Arkansas, following the *Brown v. Topeka* ruling.

- The Governor of Arkansas opposes integration, to gain votes among white people. He calls on state troopers to prevent Black students entering the school.
- The nine Black students are met by an angry mob of more than 1000 white protesters, as well as television cameras and over 250 reporters. The students cannot enter the school.
- President Eisenhower is forced to defend the Supreme Court decision on desegregation as events are broadcast worldwide (the USSR uses the media coverage to show the USA's racism).
- The 101st Airborne Division of the US Army must protect the students for the rest of the academic year.
- The Governor closes Little Rock High School the following year and schooling is disrupted across the state. Rich white parents pay for their children to attend private schools, but 50% of Black students miss their schooling that year.

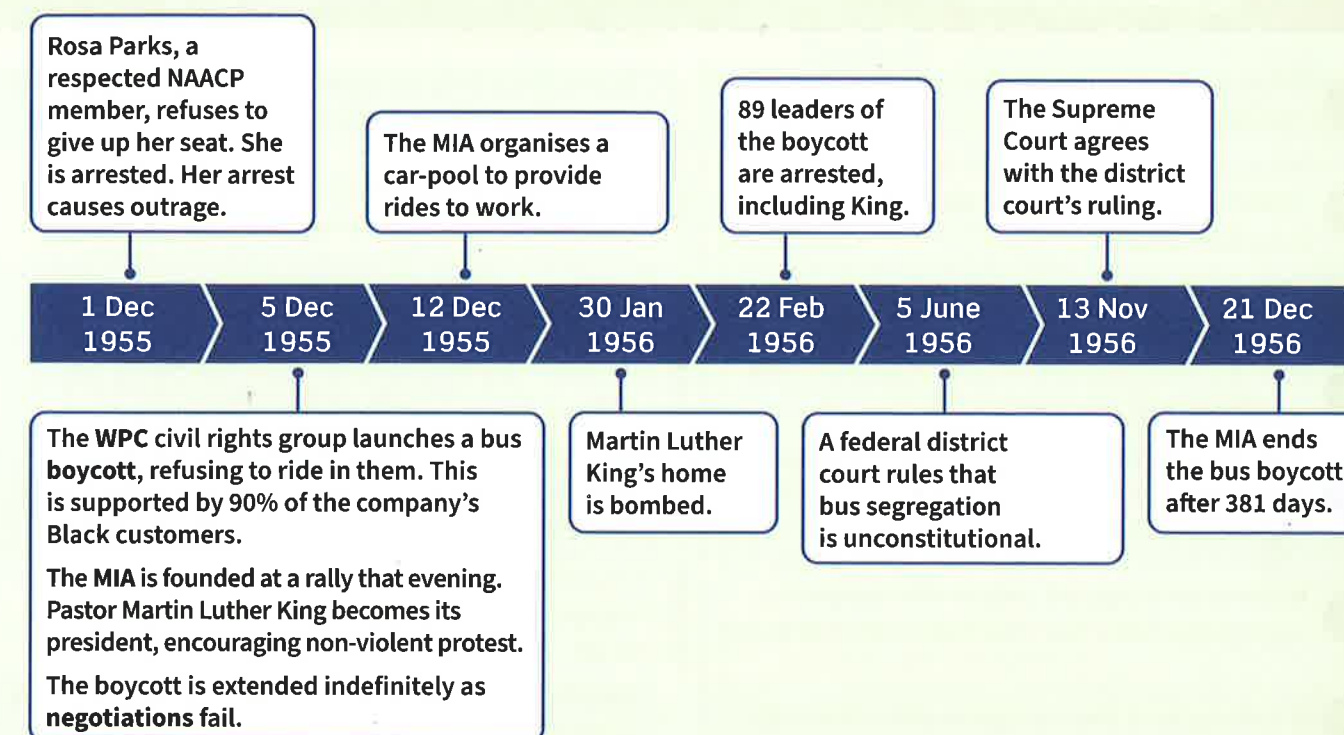
The significance of the events at Little Rock

Some important lessons emerged from Little Rock:

- ✓ Supreme Court victories were not enough to end segregation.
- ✓ Media attention was key to success, bringing international awareness.
- ✓ White northerners opposed to segregation were a powerful ally group.
- ✗ The President was reluctant to act initially, but he did defend the *Brown* ruling.
- ✗ Many white southerners supported segregation – the Governor of Arkansas was re-elected four times.
- ✗ Delaying tactics worked: Little Rock's schools were not fully integrated until 1972.

The Montgomery Bus Boycott, 1955-56

In the south in the 1950s, Black people had to sit at the back of buses and give up their seats to white people as the bus filled up. This was challenged in Montgomery.



Why was the Montgomery Bus Boycott a success?

The boycott succeeded for social, economic, and political reasons:

Social reasons	Economic reasons	Political reasons
Organisation Persistence Leadership Publicity	Loss of 40 000 fares a day. Loss of custom for city businesses. Too many participants to sack them all.	Supreme Court support Television coverage

Consequences of the Montgomery Bus Boycott

- In 1957, President Eisenhower was forced to introduce a Civil Rights Act. It was opposed by southern Democrats, but eventually passed on 9 September. It had limited impact.
- The Bus Boycott demonstrated that non-violent direct action worked. In 1957, King established the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC) to campaign against segregation and support voter registration.

REVISION TIP

Understanding the causes and consequences of key events will help you to explain *why* things happened.

Key terms

Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

Supreme Court desegregate boycott WPC MIA SCLC

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

- | | | |
|--|---|---|
| <p>1 What did the Supreme Court decide in <i>Brown v. Topeka</i>, and in which year?</p> <p>2 What did the Supreme Court fail to do in <i>Brown v. Topeka</i>, and what was the long-term effect?</p> <p>3 Why did the Governor of Arkansas oppose the integration of Little Rock High School?</p> <p>4 How did President Eisenhower respond to the events at Little Rock High School?</p> <p>5 What three things did people who opposed segregation learn from the events at Little Rock High School?</p> <p>6 What three things did people who supported segregation learn from the events at Little Rock?</p> <p>7 What triggered the Montgomery Bus Boycott?</p> <p>8 How many days did the bus boycott last?</p> <p>9 Name one economic reason why the Montgomery Bus Boycott was successful.</p> <p>10 How did President Eisenhower respond to the Montgomery Bus Boycott?</p> <p>11 What organisation did Martin Luther King form after the success of the Boycott?</p> | <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> <p>Put paper here</p> | <p>To overturn <i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> (1896) because separate educational facilities were unequal; 1954</p> <p>It failed to give a deadline for integration, so progress was slow as states delayed or resisted</p> <p>To gain votes among racist white people</p> <p>He defended the Supreme Court's decision; he ordered troops to protect Black students</p> <p>Supreme Court victories alone would not end segregation; media attention was vital; the support of white people in the north was important, too</p> <p>Delaying tactics worked; many white southerners wanted segregation; Eisenhower was reluctant to act</p> <p>Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat on a bus for a white man, and was arrested; this caused outrage</p> <p>381</p> <p>One from: loss of 40 000 bus fares a day / loss of custom for city businesses / too many participants to sack them all</p> <p>He was forced to introduce a Civil Rights Act in 1957</p> <p>The Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC)</p> |
|--|---|---|

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

- | | | |
|---|-----------------------|---|
| <p>1 Which key court case introduced the idea of 'separate but equal'?</p> <p>2 What did 'Jim Crow' state laws prevent?</p> <p>3 Until when was the US Army segregated?</p> | <p>Put paper here</p> | <p><i>Plessy v. Ferguson</i> (1896)</p> <p>They prevented Black people from accessing their rights to vote and organise</p> <p>1948</p> |
|---|-----------------------|---|

Practice

Exam-style questions

Study Sources A and B.

- 1 How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the importance of events at Little Rock in 1957? Explain your answer, using Sources A and B and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

SOURCE TIP

The terms 'coloured', 'Blacks', and 'negro' were used by white Americans to refer to Black people unfavourably in this period. You can use them when quoting directly from the sources but should otherwise never use these terms as they are offensive. Refer to 'Black people' or 'African Americans' instead.

Source A: An adapted extract from the Supreme Court's decision in *Brown v. Topeka* (1954).

Segregation has a detrimental effect upon colored children. The impact is greater when it has the approval of the law, for the policy usually suggests the inferiority of the negro group. A sense of inferiority affects the motivation of a child to learn. Segregation, therefore, has a tendency to slow down the educational and mental development of negro children and to deprive them of some of the benefits they would receive in an integrated school system. In the field of public education, the doctrine of 'separate but equal' has no place. It is inherently unequal.

Source B: An adapted extract from the Southern Manifesto, a document signed by around 100 southern Democrats in 1956.

We regard the decision of the Supreme Court as a clear abuse of power. The original Constitution does not mention education. Neither does the 14th amendment nor any other amendment. This decision by the Court, contrary to the Constitution, is creating chaos and confusion in the south. It is destroying the friendly relations between the white and Negro races that have been created through 90 years of patient effort. It has planted hatred and suspicion where there has previously been friendship and understanding.

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the importance of events at Little Rock in 1957.

- 2 What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

Interpretation 1: An adapted extract from a 2011 history book, *Cold War Civil Rights: Race and the Image of American Democracy*, by historian Mary Dudziak.

In Brown v. Topeka (1954) the Supreme Court decided that school segregation was against the US Constitution. The Brown decision made it seem that the story American propaganda told was correct, that American democracy was based on principles of justice and equality. But the events in Little Rock threatened to undermine this story. As Little Rock became a massive worldwide news story, Eisenhower was forced to act. Each incident of discrimination reinforced the importance of race to US relations with predominantly black nations elsewhere in the world.

Interpretation 2: An extract from a 1997 article called 'The Little Rock Crisis: Success or Failure for the NAACP?', by historian Adam Fairclough.

The Little Rock Crisis, followed by the Governor of Arkansas' triumphant re-election, killed the NAACP's hopes that school integration might be quick and painless. The two events revealed how great the white opposition to integration was. Southern politicians already knew that there were no votes to be won by supporting integration. They now saw that there were lots of votes to be won by appealing to the worst attitudes of white voters.

- 3 Suggest **one** reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the importance of events at Little Rock in 1957. You may use Sources A and B to help explain your answer. (4)
- 4 How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the importance of events at Little Rock in 1957? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16)



3 Opposition to the Civil Rights Movement

Southern racism and the Ku Klux Klan

Black people faced frequent violence and intimidation in the south at the hands of white racists, especially when campaigning or registering to vote.

- **Lynchings** happened across the south at the hands of mobs of white racists taking 'the law' into their own hands. Around 5000 lynchings were recorded between 1882 and 1968.
- In Mississippi in 1955, Reverend George Lee and Lamar Smith were murdered for encouraging Black people to vote. No one was arrested for either crime; Lee's shooting was filed as a car accident.

The racist organisation the **Ku Klux Klan** (KKK) was often behind the atrocities.

Racism was also found in white southern church organisations, where members were often members of the KKK.

The authorities usually looked the other way, because many police officers and judges were also members of the KKK.

Following the *Brown v. Topeka* Supreme Court decision, membership of the Ku Klux Klan increased to fight desegregation.

The Murder of Emmett Till, August 1955

Emmett Till was a 14-year-old Black boy from Chicago (in the north), who was visiting his cousins in the town of Money, Mississippi (in the south) in the summer of 1955.

Till visits a store in town, and allegedly flirts with, touches, or wolf-whistles at the owner's wife, a 21-year-old white woman.

28 August: The store owner (Bryant) and his half-brother (Milam) go to Till's great-uncle's house, armed with a gun, and kidnap Till.

Several nights later, Till's body is found in a local river. He has been beaten, mutilated, and shot in the head. His body is barely recognisable.



▲ Emmett Till

Bryant and Milam are arrested and charged with murder. It is the first time white men have been charged with the murder of a Black man in Mississippi.

Pictures of Till's body are published in local Black newspapers and picked up nationwide.

Till's mother holds an open-casket funeral, saying: 'There was just no way I could describe what was in that box. No way. And I just wanted the world to see.'

23 September: An all-white, all-male jury finds Bryant and Milam not guilty. Bryant and Milam later sell their story to a magazine for \$3500, sparking outrage.

The publicity created by Till's funeral caused anger across the USA and the world, feeding into the rapid growth of the Civil Rights Movement. However, Till's killers were never brought to justice.

Key terms

Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

lynching Ku Klux Klan manifesto
White 'Citizens' Council Dixiecrat federal



Opposition to desegregation after *Brown v. Topeka*

The day of the *Brown* ruling became known as 'Black Monday' by many white southerners. It was followed by an extreme backlash against desegregation.

- The so-called 'Southern **Manifesto**', signed by 19 Senators on 12 March 1958, publicly rejected the *Brown v. Topeka* court ruling as illegal, claiming that desegregation was unconstitutional.
- Black families with children in integrated schools were threatened with violence, as were Black and white civil rights activists. Some schools were bombed.
- Some state governors promised to keep segregation: the Senator for Virginia called for 'massive resistance' and threatened desegregating schools with closure.
- In July 1954, the first **White Citizens' Council** (WCC) was set up, in Indianola, Mississippi. Many more WCCs appeared across the south, drawing

greater middle-class membership than the KKK. By 1957, national membership of WCCs had reached around 250 000. The WCC threatened to sack Black workers and to use violence against them.

- Many local groups spring up to protest desegregation, often set up by white parents to threaten and intimidate Black people and their supporters.
- Many school boards find ways to resist desegregating, e.g. using admission tests to limit the number of Black students; using white protests as an excuse to exclude Black students 'for their own safety'.

Many Black people felt worse off after the *Brown* ruling than they had before: winning rights was one thing; enforcing them was another entirely. The NAACP and CORE worked with children in integrated schools to prepare them for the hostility they would face.

Political opposition to desegregation

Political opposition to desegregation occurred at both the local and state level.

- President Eisenhower was reluctant to force states to desegregate. He even spoke against the 1957 Civil Rights Act after reluctantly putting it forward.
- In the capital (Washington, D.C.), southern Senators and southern members of the House of Representatives in Congress used speeches and delaying tactics to block civil rights legislation, knowing that this would appeal to white voters.
- Southern Democrat politicians, known as '**Dixiecrats**', resisted by amending or slowing

down civil rights legislation; there were too many Dixiecrats for their views to be ignored. Dixiecrats claimed they were not racist, but were fighting for the right of each state to make its own rules.

- 77 Southern Members of the House of Representatives signed the 'Southern Manifesto' in 1958 (see above).
- Judges and juries in the southern courts refused to convict white people of crimes against Black people and ignored Black-on-Black crimes. Black Americans could not serve on juries and there were no Black judges.

Features of the Civil Rights Act, 1957

The weaknesses of the 1957 Civil Rights Act showed the strength of opposition to it, and the difficulties of enforcing the law:

Features of the Civil Rights Act, 1957	Was it a success?
✓ Stated that all Americans had the right to vote.	✗ In the south, only 3% more Black Americans were registered to vote in 1960 than had voted in 1957.
✓ Allowed federal courts to prosecute when people were denied the right to vote.	✗ Cases took a long time to reach federal courts; few had been heard by 1965, and all-white courts were unsympathetic.
✓ Six-member Commission to write a report on civil rights for the president.	✗ Gathered information that contributed to later Acts.

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

1	Why were Reverend George Lee and Lamar Smith murdered in 1955?	Put paper here	For encouraging Black people to vote
2	What was the Ku Klux Klan?	Put paper here	A racist organisation that encouraged white violence towards Black people
3	Who was Emmett Till?	Put paper here	A 14-year-old Black boy from Chicago, murdered in Mississippi in 1955
4	Why was Till attacked?	Put paper here	He allegedly flirted with/touched/wolf-whistled a 21-year-old white woman
5	Why was the Till case unique in Mississippi history?	Put paper here	It was the first time white men had been tried for the murder of a Black man
6	What was notable about the make-up of the jury in the Till case?	Put paper here	The jury was all-male and all-white
7	What document opposing desegregation was signed by nearly all southern Senators after the <i>Brown</i> ruling?	Put paper here	The Southern Manifesto
8	Who joined the White Citizens' Councils?	Put paper here	Mostly middle-class southern whites who supported segregation
9	Who were the Dixiecrats?	Put paper here	Southern Democrat politicians opposed to desegregation
10	How did the Dixiecrats oppose desegregation?	Put paper here	Amended and slowed down civil rights legislation; fought for the right of each state to make its own rules
11	Give two reasons why the 1957 Civil Rights Act was not a success.	Put paper here	In the south, only 3% more Black people registered to vote in 1960 than in 1957; cases took a long time to reach federal courts; all-white courts were unsympathetic

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

1	How were literacy tests used to prevent Black people from registering to vote?	Put paper here	They contained questions that were very difficult to answer, making it hard to pass
2	How did President Eisenhower respond to the events at Little Rock High School?	Put paper here	He defended the Supreme Court's decision; he ordered troops to protect Black students
3	How did President Eisenhower respond to the Montgomery Bus Boycott?	Put paper here	He was forced to introduce a Civil Rights Act in 1957

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: An article from the *Detroit Tribune* newspaper, published in Michigan on 1 October 1965. It describes a protest meeting following the murder of Emmett Till.

12,000 at Emmett Till Sunday Protest Meeting

NAACP EMMETT TILL PROTEST MEETING at Bethel A.M.E. Church last Sunday drew an estimated 12,000 people. Some five to six thousand were unable to get into Bethel (4,000 jammed into a 2,500 capacity auditorium). Scott Methodist [Church], two blocks away, was opened where 2,000 were seated. Four or five thousand others were in the streets between the two churches. [Congressman] Charles C. Diggs Jr., and Medgar Evers were the principal speakers. Mr. Evers is secretary of the Mississippi branch of NAACP.

- 1 Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about the murder of Emmett Till. (4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

(i) What I can infer:	
Details in the source that tell me this:	
(ii) What I can infer:	
Details in the source that tell me this:	

- 2 Explain why it was difficult for Black people to stand up for their civil rights in southern states in the late 1950s. (12)

You may use the following in your answer:
• lynching
• threat of losing their jobs
You must also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

'Why' questions are asking about causation. You need to give clear reasons for the factor in the question. A strong answer would give three clear, separate reasons.

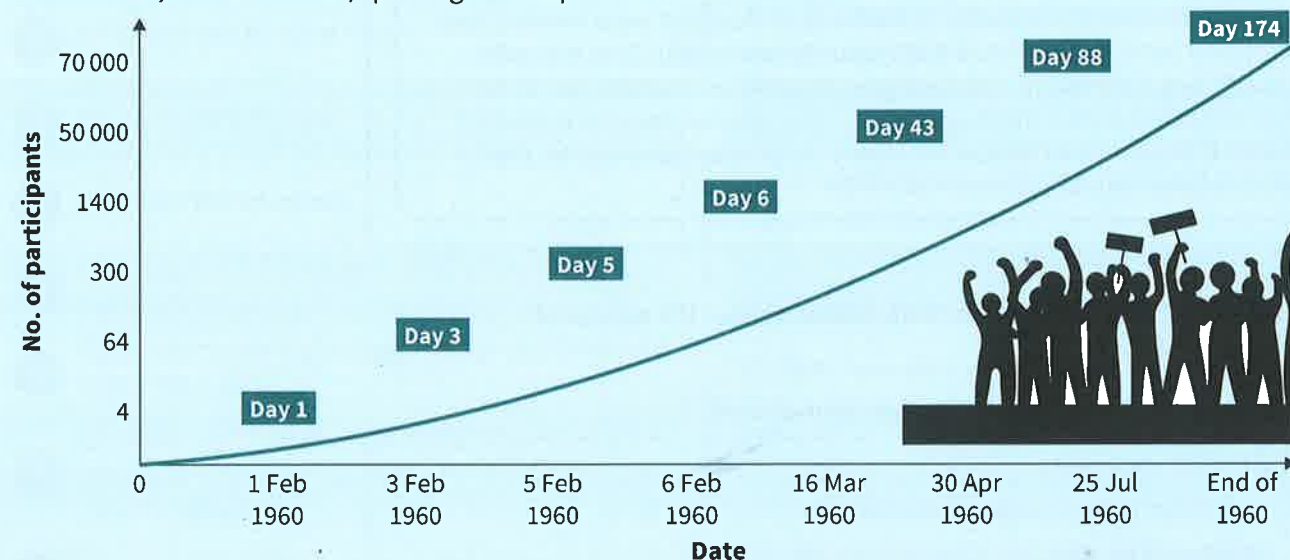
You do not have to use the two reasons provided in the bullets, but you will need to come up with at least one fresh reason of your own if you do leave them out.



4 The Civil Rights Movement, 1960-65

Greensboro and the sit-in movement, 1960

The next stage of the Civil Rights Movement involved students. They were willing to take greater risks, because they did not have families to look after or jobs that could be threatened by the White Citizens' Councils. Students were idealistic and willing to make sacrifices. They took matters into their own hands, first in Greensboro, North Carolina, sparking a widespread movement.



Day 1: Four Black college students ask to be served at a whites-only **lunch counter** in Greensboro, North Carolina. They are refused service and asked to leave. However, the students stay – without being served – until closing.

Day 3: The four students are joined by 60 others. None is served. They are threatened by some white customers.

Day 5: 300 students queue to sit at the lunch counter. As each one is removed by customers or police, another replaces them. Threats turn into assaults: coffee and ketchup are poured onto the students and cigarettes are stubbed out on them.

Day 6: 1400 protesters arrive at the store and are met by counter-protesters.

Day 43: President Eisenhower expresses concern over the ongoing protests, saying he is sympathetic to those striving to enjoy civil rights.

Day 88: Sit-ins spread to all the southern states (55 cities).

Day 174: The original lunch counter, at Woolworths in Greensboro, is desegregated; by this time the store has lost the equivalent of \$1.8 million in today's money.

End of 1960: Over 70 000 people take part in sit-ins across the country.

Consequences of the sit-in movement

- The sit-ins attracted huge publicity because of the contrast between the non-violent patience of the protesters and the brutal treatment they faced from angry white customers. Once again, such racism made the USA look bad internationally and was used in anti-USA propaganda by the USSR.
- As the sit-in movement grew, volunteers from the NAACP and CORE helped with organisation and training.
- In April 1960, activist students involved with sit-ins formed their own group: the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (**SNCC**), drawing on Martin Luther King's principles of non-violent protest.

Key terms

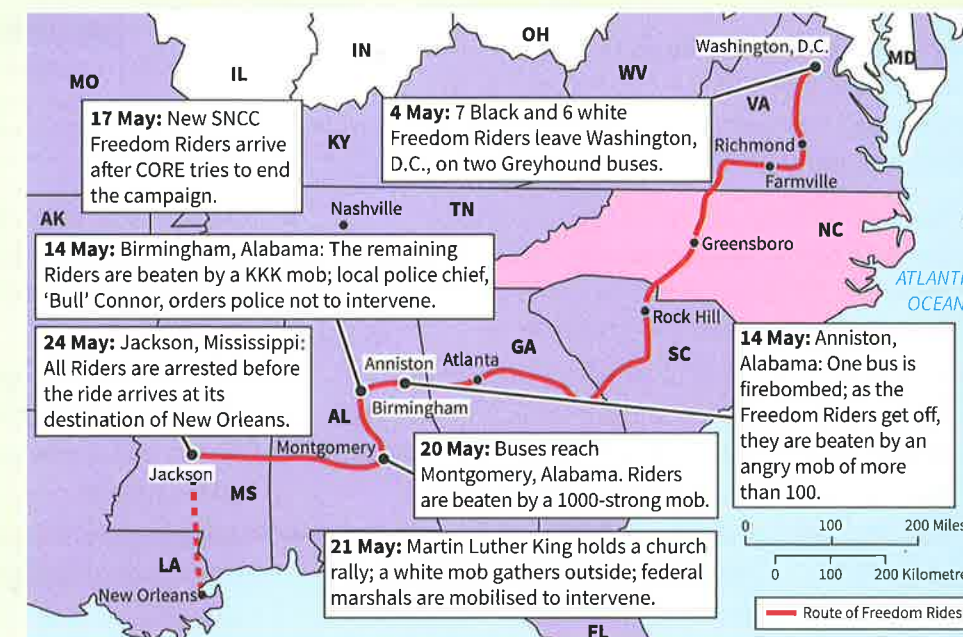
Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

lunch counter SNCC
Freedom Ride

The Freedom Rides, 1961

Direct action had targeted schools, local buses, restaurants, and other public places. The next target was interstate travel.

- In the north, Black people on Greyhound buses could sit anywhere, but they had to move to the back when they reached the south.
- In December 1960, the Supreme Court ordered the desegregation of bus station facilities.
- In 1961, CORE decided to see if this had been carried out. Retrying an event from 1947, CORE launched a '**Freedom Ride**' from north to south.



Consequences of the Freedom Rides

- Freedom Rides continued through the summer of 1961, with the same results.
- King appealed to Robert Kennedy, the Attorney General and brother of new Democrat President John F. Kennedy, but progress to protect the riders was slow.
- Over 300 Freedom Riders were arrested and imprisoned.
- On 1 November 1961, the government threatened to enforce desegregation laws if states did not comply.

REVISION TIP

Consequences are key to explaining the significance – or importance – of events.

James Meredith and the University of Mississippi, 1962

In 1961, President Kennedy promised to be more proactive in supporting the Civil Rights Movement than Eisenhower had been. However, he had shown little support for the Freedom Riders. In 1962, Kennedy had a chance to make amends.

1961	1962	1962/3
Seven years after <i>Brown v. Topeka</i> , there are still no integrated schools in Mississippi. James Meredith, a Black American, applies to the University of Mississippi ('Ole Miss'). Meredith is rejected and takes the university to court, eventually reaching the Supreme Court.	10 September: The Supreme Court rules that Meredith must be admitted to the university. 30 September: Meredith is physically prevented from registering by the university, so Kennedy orders over 500 federal marshals to the campus to enable him to do so. 1 October: Marshals accompany Meredith through a crowd of 2500 protesters, who throw acid and Molotov cocktails (handmade petrol bombs). Two people are killed in the riot, including a French journalist, and several hundred are injured. Of the 300 people arrested, only 100 come from Mississippi.	Troops remain on campus with Meredith throughout his year-long course.

4 The Civil Rights Movement, 1960-65

The 1963 peace march in Birmingham, Alabama

The reaction in Birmingham, Alabama, when the Freedom Riders passed through, made this city an ideal target for King and the SCLC's new 'Project C'. This aimed to confront southern racism head on by provoking violence and gaining widespread media attention.

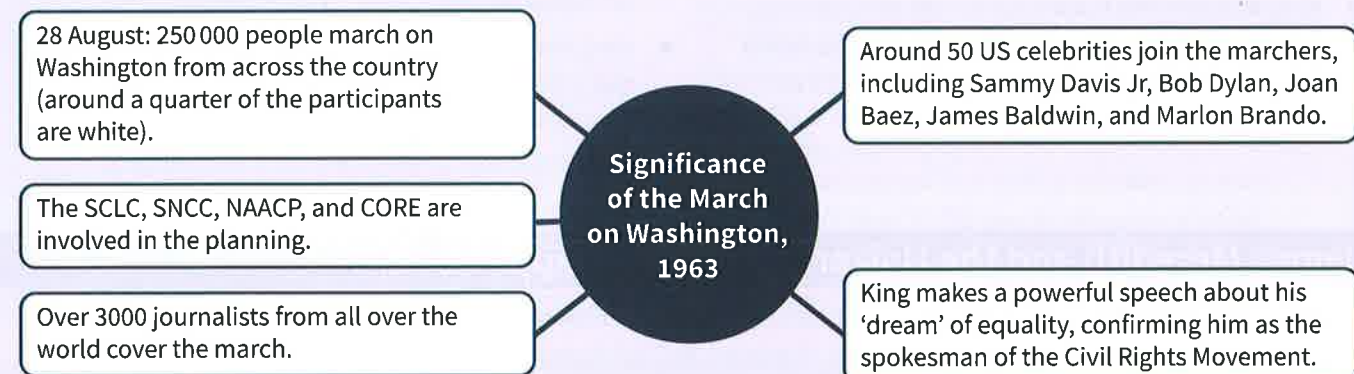
REVISION TIP

It is important to try to remember factual details to add weight to your answers, such as just how many children were arrested.

- Birmingham was known as 'Bombingham' because of the frequent attacks on Black churches, homes, and businesses there. It remained completely segregated.
- On 3 April 1963, the SCLC began a campaign of sit-ins, protest marches, and economic boycotts. The SCLC encouraged children as young as five to march.
- Over 900 children were arrested, filling all the available jail space. King was also arrested. Police Chief 'Bull' Connor used police dogs and firehoses to disrupt the marches.
- Media images of the event were incredibly powerful and included TV footage of children's hands poking through the bars of the crowded jails.
- President Kennedy got involved, saying that these events had 'damaged America'. Talks began, Connor was removed, and the city agreed to desegregate.
- Pro-segregation reactions forced Kennedy to send in 3000 federal troops.

The 1963 'March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom'

Martin Luther King planned a centenary march to celebrate the passing of the Thirteenth Amendment, to highlight the lack of progress in civil rights both economically and politically.



King's leadership

Many saw King's leadership as central to the success of the Civil Rights Movement:

- ✓ educated
- ✓ Christian values
- ✓ non-violent
- ✓ passionate and charismatic speaker



▲ King addresses the crowd at the March on Washington, 28 August 1963

Freedom Summer, 1964

In June 1964, the *New York Times* ran an article entitled 'Mississippi: A Profile of the Nation's Most Segregated State'. In Mississippi in 1964, 'Jim Crow' state laws still existed and only 7% of the Black population (about 40% of the state population) were eligible to vote.

The SNCC and CORE therefore made Mississippi a key target for their campaigns.

- Volunteers taught people how to pass literacy tests and supported 17 000 Black Mississippians in attempting to register to vote. Only 1600 were accepted.
- The Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party (MFDP) and 30 Freedom Schools were established, all run by volunteers.
- Volunteers were mostly students, Black and white. They received training on dealing with harassment, arrests, imprisonment, and abuse.
- On 21 June 1964, three volunteers disappeared. Police in Neshoba County, Mississippi, failed to investigate and the FBI was called in. The bodies of the three young men were found on 4 August. They had been murdered by members of the local KKK.

Kennedy, Johnson, and the Civil Rights Act, 1964

After promising support in his election campaign, Kennedy introduced his Civil Rights Act in 1963. However, it faced the same opposition as Eisenhower's Act in 1957.

- On 22 November 1963, President Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas, Texas, and his Vice President, Lyndon B. Johnson, replaced him.
- Kennedy's assassination allowed Johnson to present the Civil Rights Act as Kennedy's 'legacy', making it much more difficult for the Dixiecrats to dilute the legislation. It passed by 290 votes to 130.

The 1964 Civil Rights Act:

- ✓ banned segregation in all public spaces
- ✓ banned job discrimination
- ✓ was enforced by a new Equal Opportunities Commission
- ✗ did not *explicitly* ban voter discrimination in individual states.

The Voting Rights Act, 1965

Johnson reacted to Selma by passing the Voting Rights Act in August 1965.

Nearly 250 000 new Black voters registered that year and numbers continued to increase rapidly.

The 1965 Voting Rights Act:

- ✓ outlawed literacy tests and poll taxes as ways of deciding who could vote
- ✓ enabled federal officials to monitor voter registration instead of state officials.

Selma, 1965

The 1964 Civil Rights Act was a huge step forward, but it failed to protect voting rights. The SCLC worked with the SNCC in Selma, Alabama, to help tackle this. Selma had fewer white people than Black people, but it had the lowest rate of Black voter registration in Alabama.

By this time, King was at the height of his fame and influence: in 1964, he had been named *TIME* magazine's 'Man of the Year' and been awarded a Nobel Peace Prize.

- The campaign featured sit-ins and boycotts.
- On 7 March 1965, 600 protesters tried to march from Selma to Montgomery (the state capital) to present a petition to the Governor of Alabama. The petition demanded protection for Black voting rights.
- King expected the Selma Police Chief to react violently, resulting in increased media exposure.
- Police stopped the march, tear-gassed the protesters, and beat them with clubs. The event became known as 'Bloody Sunday'.
- Johnson brought in the National Guard to support the marchers.
- Ten days later, 25 000 people completed the march and presented the petition.

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

- | Questions | Answers |
|--|--|
| 1 Where did the 1960 sit-ins begin? | Greensboro, North Carolina |
| 2 Which group was formed during the sit-ins? | Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) |
| 3 What kind of bus journeys did the Freedom Riders go on? | Interstate bus journeys (as opposed to local buses) |
| 4 How did opponents of desegregation try to disrupt the Freedom Rides? | Firebombed the bus at Anniston; dragged Riders off buses and beat them; beat them when the buses stopped; Riders were arrested |
| 5 How many protectors and protesters were present when James Meredith tried to register at 'Ole Miss'? | Over 500 federal marshals to protect him, and 2500 protesters |
| 6 What was Birmingham, Alabama's nickname and why? | 'Bombingham', because of the frequent attacks on Black churches, homes, and businesses there |
| 7 How many children were arrested during the Birmingham campaign? | Over 900 |
| 8 Why did the 1963 march on Washington gain significant press attention? | There were 250 000 marchers; celebrities took part; it was on the anniversary of the Thirteenth Amendment; King's famous 'I have a dream' speech |
| 9 Why was Mississippi targeted in the Freedom Summer? | It was seen as the most segregated state; only 7% of the Black population were registered to vote |
| 10 Which President passed the Civil Rights Act, and in which year? | Lyndon B. Johnson in 1964 |
| 11 Why did the SCLC try to organise a campaign in Selma? | Selma was predominantly Black but had the lowest rate of Black voter registration in Alabama |
| 12 How effective was the Voting Rights Act of 1965? | Very. Almost 250 000 extra Black people were registered to vote by the end of 1965 |

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

- | Questions | Answers |
|---|---|
| 1 How many days did the bus boycott last? | 381 |
| 2 What was the Ku Klux Klan? | A racist organisation that encouraged violence towards Black people |
| 3 Who were the Dixiecrats? | Southern Democrat politicians opposed to desegregation |

Practice

Exam-style questions

Study Sources A and B.

- 1 How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the importance of the different participants in the fight for civil rights in Mississippi in the years 1961 to 1962? Explain your answer, using Sources A and B and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

Source A: An extract from a statement made by Attorney General Robert Kennedy on 24 May 1961.

Very difficult conditions now exist in the states of Mississippi and Alabama. Besides the groups of 'Freedom Riders' travelling through these states, there are curiosity seekers, publicity seekers, and others who are seeking to serve their own causes, as well as many persons who are travelling because they must use the interstate carriers to reach their destination. In this confused situation, there is an increasing possibility that innocent persons may be injured. A mob asks no questions. A cooling off period is needed.

Source B: An extract from a radio speech by Democratic Governor of Mississippi Ross Barnett on 13 September 1962, shortly before James Meredith tried to register at the University of Mississippi.

Even now ... professional agitators and the unfriendly liberal press and other trouble makers are pouring across our borders intent upon instigating strife among our people. Paid propagandists are continually hammering away at us in the hope that they can succeed in bringing about a division among us. Every effort is being made to intimidate us into submission to the tyranny of judicial oppression. The Kennedy Administration is lending the power of the federal government to the ruthless demands of these agitators.

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the importance of the different participants in the fight for civil rights in Mississippi in the years 1961 to 1962.

- 2 What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

Interpretation 1: University of Mississippi historian William H. Doherty quoted in 'The Fight for Men's Minds': *The Aftermath of the Ole Miss Riot of 1962* by Charles W. Eagles (2009).

In 1973 Doherty criticised the moral failure of participants in 1962 and the 'bland journalists and historians' who judged events in terms of politics and not morality. Though he also criticised James Meredith for 'undue individualism' and ignorance of the larger Civil Rights Movement, Doherty agreed that Meredith 'did nothing immoral' and had given a 'heroic solo performance.' Doherty reserved his harshest judgement for state and national leaders. He blamed the Kennedys for failing to understand Mississippi, its leaders, and the political pressures on the university.

Interpretation 2: Adapted from *A Thousand Days: John F. Kennedy in the White House* by Arthur M. Schlesinger, Jr (1965).

Though some American Negroes felt Kennedy might have acted sooner this was quickly forgotten as they watched him send the Army to aid the admission of Meredith. In the autumn elections the Democrats won more Negro votes than ever. Then on November 20 Kennedy finally issued the executive order on housing. it marked a new step toward equal opportunity. In the middle of 1963, when a poll asked Negroes who had done most for Negro rights, the first three were the NAACP, Martin Luther King, Jr, and President Kennedy.

- 3 Suggest **one** reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the importance of the different participants in the fight for civil rights in Mississippi in the years 1961 to 1962. You may use Sources A and B to help explain your answer. (4)
- 4 How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the importance of the different participants in the fight for civil rights in Mississippi in the years 1961 to 1962? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16)

